

How to Play Tavli

THE GAME · ΤΟ ΠΑΙΧΝΙΔΙ

How to Play Tavli

Πόρτες · Πλακωτό · Φεύγα

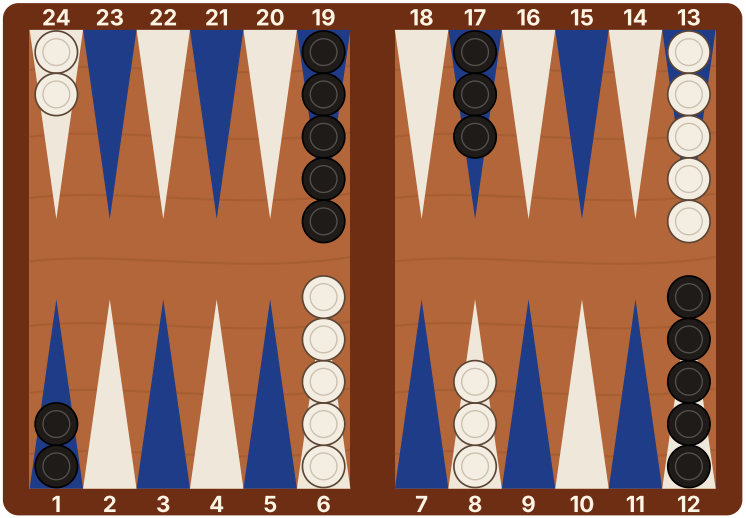
Tavli is the Greek name for backgammon, and it's played as three games rather than one. A match moves from Portes to Plakoto to Fevga and then starts again, all on the same board with the same checkers.

2
players

3
games

15
checkers each

5 or 7
points to win a match



A board set for Portes, the first game of every match.

WHERE IT COMES FROM

Older than the kafeneio

The word τάβλι comes from the Byzantine *tavla*, and before that the Latin *tabula*. Romans and Byzantines played race games on boards like this more than a thousand years ago, and the game has been part of Greek life ever since. You'll find a board in every kafeneio and on most family tables after Sunday lunch, and it's usually a grandparent who teaches you to play.

Mavrikis Designs started with one of those boards: the one my pappou made by hand.

HOW A MATCH WORKS

Three games in turn, on the same board. Each game won scores 1 point, or 2 for a mars. Matches usually go to 5 or 7 points, and the winner of each game usually starts the next.

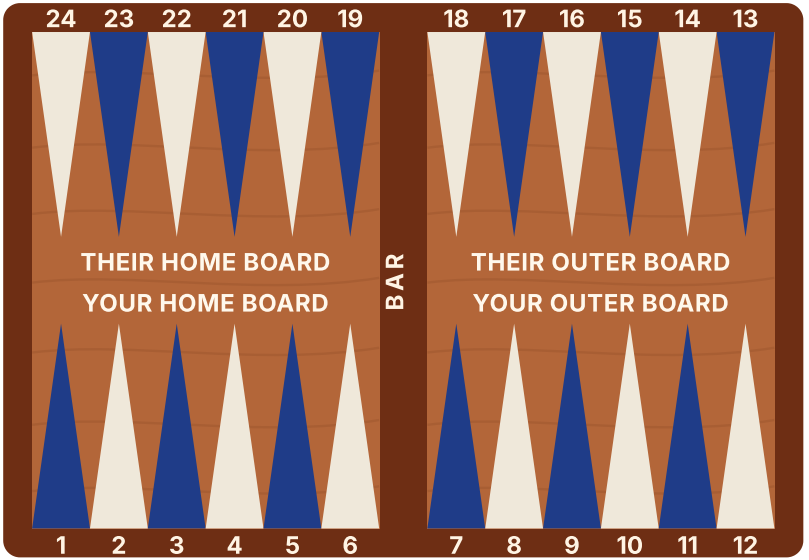
1. **Portes** · Πόρτες, doors
   The closest to international backgammon. Build doors, hit single checkers, race home.

2. **Plakoto** · Πλακωτό, pinned
   No hitting. You trap checkers by landing on them.

3. **Fevga** · Φεύγα, run
   Both players move the same way. One checker holds a point.

BEFORE YOU ROLL

Know your board



Seen from your side of the table. Some players keep their home board on the right.

The points
24 triangles, numbered from your side: 1 is bottom left, 24 is top left.

Your home board
Points 1 to 6. All 15 checkers must reach it before you bear off.

Your outer board
Points 7 to 12, crossed on the way home.

Their side
Points 13 to 24. Their 1-point is your 24-point.

The bar
The ridge down the middle. In Portes, hit checkers wait here.

Checkers and dice
15 checkers (πούλια) each and two dice (ζάρια).

THE BASICS

Rules all three games share

01 Who starts

Each player rolls one die and the higher number goes first. Depending on your table, they either play those two numbers or roll again.

02 Moving

Each die is a separate move. Roll 5 and 3 and you can move one checker 5 and another 3, or a single checker 8, as long as it can stop after the first die.

03 Doubles

A double is played four times. Double fours (ντόρτια) means four moves of 4.

04 Use the whole roll

If you can play both dice, you must. If only one fits, play the bigger number if you can. If neither fits, you pass.

05 Bearing off

Once all 15 checkers are in your home board, you take them off. A 4 takes one off your 4-point; a bigger number can take off your furthest checker.

06 Scoring

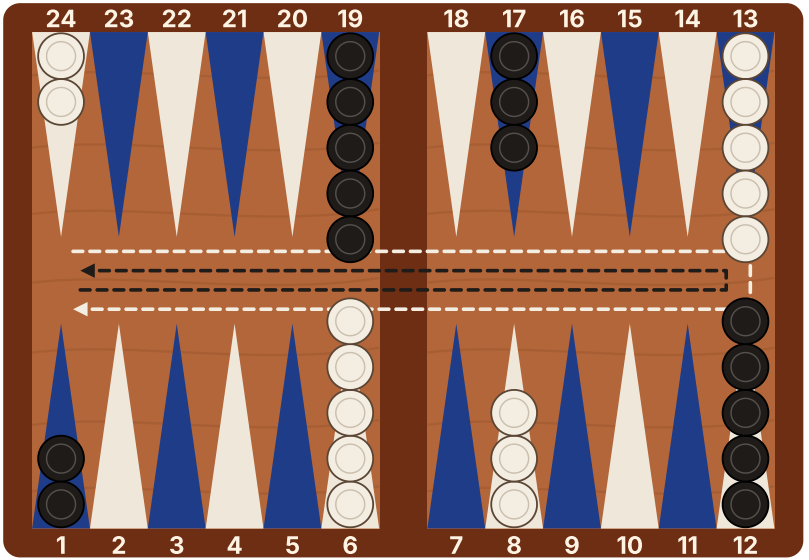
First to bear off all 15 wins 1 point, or 2 for a mars (μαρς): a win where the loser hasn't taken off a single checker. No doubling cube.

GAME 1 OF 3

Portes

Πόρτες · *doors*

The closest of the three to international backgammon. You build doors, hit single checkers and race your checkers home.



- You (light): 24 to 1, clockwise into your home board, bottom left
- Your opponent (dark): 1 to 24, the opposite way

SETTING UP

From your side: 2 checkers on your 24-point, 5 on your 13, 3 on your 8 and 5 on your 6. Your opponent mirrors you exactly.

PORTES CONTINUED

HOW IT PLAYS

1. Two or more of your checkers on a point make a **door** (πόρτα). Your opponent can't land there.
2. A checker standing on its own is exposed. Land on it and you **hit** it, sending it to the bar.
3. A checker on the bar must come back in before its owner moves anything else. It enters in the opponent's home board, on the point matching the die, counted from the edge. If every point it could enter on is a door, the turn is lost.
4. Six doors in a row make a wall that no checker can get past.

HOW YOU WIN

Bear off all 15 first. If your opponent hasn't borne off a single checker by then, it's a mars and you score 2 points instead of 1.

BEGINNER TIPS

- Make your 5-point early. It's the most valuable door on the board.
- Don't leave single checkers within six points of an opposing checker unless you have to.
- Hit when it costs you little. A checker sent to the bar starts its journey again.

HOUSE RULES

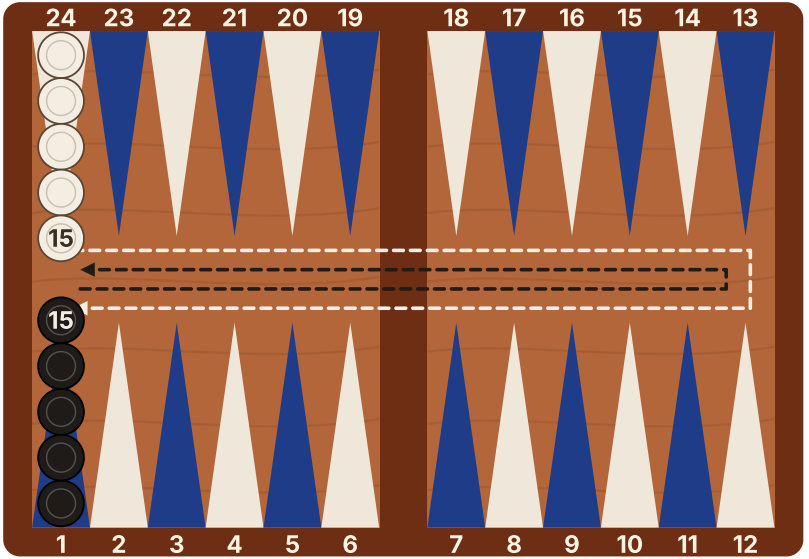
Some tables play a triple win, a backgammon, when the loser still has a checker on the bar or in the winner's home board. Traditional tavli doesn't, so agree first.

GAME 2 OF 3

Plakoto

Πλακωτό · from πλακώνω, to press down

There is no hitting. You trap your opponent's checkers by landing on them, and if you trap the last checker on their starting point, you win outright.



- You: all 15 start on your 24-point and travel 24 to 1
- Your opponent: all 15 start on your 1-point and travel the other way

SETTING UP

All 15 of your checkers start on your 24-point. Your opponent's 15 start directly across, on your 1-point. You race past each other in opposite directions.

PLAKOTO CONTINUED

HOW IT PLAYS

1. Land on a single opposing checker and you **pin** it. It can't move until your checker leaves.
2. A pinned point belongs to the player on top. You can stack more of your own checkers there.
3. Two or more checkers of one colour on a point are safe. Nobody can land on them.
4. The **mana** (μάνα, 'mother') is the last checker left on a player's starting point. Pin it before it gets away and you win on the spot.



A pin. The light checker sits on a single dark one. The dark checker can't move until the light checker moves on.

HOW YOU WIN

Bear off all 15 first, or pin your opponent's mana. A mana win or a mars (your opponent hasn't borne off a single checker) scores 2 points.

BEGINNER TIPS

- Guard your mana. Leaving it alone in the opening is the quickest way to lose.
- A pin only lasts while you stay on it. Once you move off, their checker is free again.
- Pins early in your opponent's journey hurt most: the trapped checker still has the whole board to cross.

HOUSE RULES

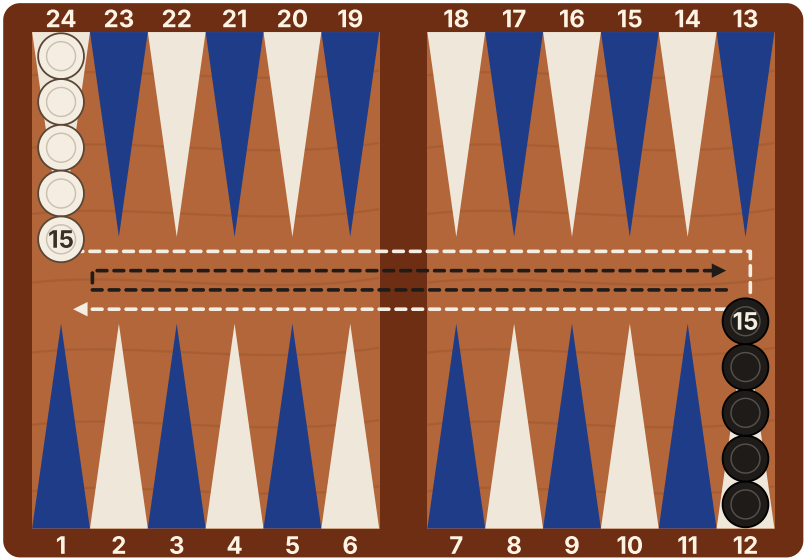
If both mothers end up pinned, many tables call the game a draw.

GAME 3 OF 3

Fevga

Φεύγα · run, get going

Both players move the same way round the board, and a single checker is enough to hold a point. The game is won by blocking.



- You: start top left, travel clockwise into your home board, bottom left
- Your opponent: starts bottom right, travels clockwise too, home is top right

SETTING UP

All 15 of your checkers start on your 24-point, in the far left-hand corner. Your opponent starts in the diagonally opposite corner, and you both travel clockwise.

FEVGA CONTINUED

HOW IT PLAYS

1. There is no hitting and no pinning. A **single checker holds a point**: you can never land where your opponent has a checker.
2. Before you move a second checker off your starting point, your first one has to get past your opponent's starting point.
3. You may not build six points in a row to wall your opponent in, unless at least one of their checkers is already past it.

HOUSE RULES

Some tables also forbid holding all six points of your opponent's starting quarter. Fevga has more family variations than the other two games, so settle the blocking rules before you roll.

HOW YOU WIN

Bear off all 15 first. If your opponent hasn't borne off a single checker by then, that's a mars (μαρς) and you score 2 points instead of 1.

BEGINNER TIPS

- Spread out. Every point you hold is one your opponent can't use.
- Claim points just ahead of your opponent's starting corner. That's where their checkers need room most.
- Watch your own stack. A good opponent will build points in front of it and leave you with nowhere to go.

AT THE TABLE

Speak like you've played for years

τάβλι
TAVLI
The board and the match

πούλια
POULIA
The checkers

ζάρια
ZARIA
The dice

πόρτα
PORTA
A point held by two or more checkers

μάνα
MANA
'Mother': last checker on the start point

μαρς
MARS
A win worth 2 points

εξάρες
EXARES
Double six

πεντάρες
PENTARES
Double five

ντόρτια
DORTIA
Double four

TABLE MANNERS

Play quickly
Take too long over a move and the people watching will tell you.

Call your roll
Say the numbers out loud as they land.

Roll properly
Both dice land flat, on your right-hand side, or both are rolled again.

Snap the checkers
The sound on solid wood is part of the game.

Talk
Teasing your opponent is fine. Touching their checkers isn't.